

Maya knew the strategy was right. That was what made the situation so difficult.

She had spent three months helping the CEO shape a new corporate strategy for the organisation. The business had become too complex, too slow and too fragmented. It had accumulated layers of products, businesses and processes that had once made sense but were now consuming capital and management attention. The new strategy was uncompromising: three legacy businesses would be exited, investment would move aggressively into digital platforms, several functions would be consolidated, decision rights would be redistributed, and performance expectations would change. Some senior executives would lose responsibilities; others would gain them.

The board had approved the strategy unanimously. The CEO had been equally clear with Maya: the organisation knew where it needed to go; her job was to get it there.

Maya was good at this sort of thing. She was decisive, understood organisational politics and had built a reputation for getting difficult programmes moving when others were still debating them. She knew how to translate strategy into execution and how to mobilise senior people around difficult decisions.

So she began.

At first, everything went well. Maya met with the affected executives, listened to their concerns and explained the rationale for the strategy. She reassured people that the transformation was not about individuals but about the future of the organisation. But then resistance began. A regional CEO objected to the closure of one of the legacy businesses. A long-serving executive argued that the

board did not fully understand the consequences. Several senior managers began asking for exceptions to the implementation timetable.

Maya responded by doing what she believed good leadership required. She protected relationships. She gave people time. She allowed certain exceptions. She privately reassured executives that she understood their concerns, and she postponed a difficult conversation with one particularly influential executive who had begun quietly undermining the strategy.

Six months later, the programme was behind schedule.

When the CEO asked Maya what was happening, she was frustrated.

"People are resisting change."

The CEO looked at her for a moment.

"Or perhaps we're not making the decisions we said we would make."

It was an uncomfortable moment because Maya realised that something had changed. She had started with a legitimate concern for people and relationships, but somewhere along the way, that concern had begun to determine what she was willing to do.

Her judgement was beginning to run riot.

The Bearing Beneath Executive Judgement

Executives rarely experience their own judgement as irrational. Maya certainly did not think she was avoiding difficult decisions. She thought she was being responsible. That is precisely what makes worldview dynamics so consequential.

The Executive Sextant approaches executive judgement through three underlying worldview dimensions: Relational Obligation, Legitimacy and Agency. They represent three fundamental questions that sit beneath consequential executive decisions.

Relational Obligation asks: *Who am I responsible to—and what do my relationships require of me?* It concerns commitments, relationships, loyalty, belonging, stewardship and the obligations an executive perceives toward people and the institution.

Legitimacy asks: *What is right, appropriate and defensible?* It concerns principles, fairness, accountability, rules, standards and the justification for action.

Agency asks: *What can I do—and what can I enable others to do?* It concerns influence, authority, decisiveness, control and the capacity to translate intention into action.

The Three Colors of Worldview material provides a useful conceptual foundation for understanding these dynamics through its Honor/Shame, Innocence/Guilt and Power/Fear worldview drivers. These describe different ways of interpreting situations and determining appropriate action. The Executive Sextant translates these dynamics into the language of executive judgement:

Honor/Shame becomes Relational Obligation; Innocence/Guilt becomes Legitimacy; and Power/Fear becomes Agency.

None of these orientations is inherently superior. Each provides something an executive needs. Relational Obligation can create stewardship and loyalty. Legitimacy can create accountability and consistency. Agency can create movement and decisiveness. The problem begins when one of these strengths becomes so dominant that it starts to silence the others. The original Three Colors material similarly distinguishes between constructive expression, overuse and the shadow side of each worldview driver.

That is when executive judgement can run riot.

When Relational Obligation Runs Riot

Maya eventually confronted the executive who had been resisting the strategy. But instead of challenging him directly, she asked him what he needed. He told her that his people were anxious and that the proposed changes would destroy years of work. Maya understood his concerns and agreed to delay the restructuring of his division by another quarter.

Then another executive approached her. Maya made another concession. Each individual decision seemed reasonable. After all, transformation is difficult. People matter. Relationships matter. Trust matters.

And Maya's instinct was not wrong.

The Honor/Shame material describes a worldview in which relationships, belonging and bringing honour to one's people are important organising principles. Communication and business dealings can be strongly relationship-driven, with interactions affecting the relational standing of those involved.

The difficulty was that Maya had stopped asking whether her relational commitments were still serving the broader purpose. She had moved from asking, *"How do I honour the relationships I have?"* to asking, *"How do I avoid damaging these relationships?"* Those are not the same question.

Her Relational Obligation had become relational capture. She was protecting relationships that needed to be challenged and preserving commitments that were no longer aligned with the organisation's strategic direction. She was beginning to confuse loyalty with leadership.

Eventually, the CEO intervened. The executive Maya had been protecting was removed from the programme. Maya was initially surprised and then angry. But slowly she began to understand what had happened. Her concern for people had not disappeared; it had become unbalanced.

The question was not whether Maya needed to become less relational. The corrective question was: "What is my responsibility to the organisation as a whole—not merely to the individuals with whom I have relationships?"

The original Three Colors material offers an important parallel. It identifies how shame can become disabling when it generates discomfort, suffering, resignation or oppression rather than constructive change. For an executive, the equivalent danger is allowing the desire to preserve relationships to prevent necessary action.

Maya needed to bring another bearing into the decision: Legitimacy. She also needed Agency. She needed to ask not only who she was responsible to, but what was right and what she was actually prepared to do.

When Legitimacy Runs Riot

The next phase of the strategy was different. Maya decided she would never again allow relationships to interfere with execution. She introduced governance mechanisms. Every major initiative required formal approval. Every exception had to be documented. Every performance issue had to be supported by evidence. Every significant decision needed a clear rationale.

This time Maya felt in control.

The rules were clear. The strategy was defensible. Nobody could accuse her of making arbitrary decisions. Yet something strange happened. People became cautious. They stopped bringing her half-formed ideas and became reluctant to experiment. Managers increasingly asked, *"Is this allowed?"* rather than, *"Would this help?"*

Maya had solved one problem and created another.

Her strength in Legitimacy had become excessive.

The Innocence/Guilt material describes the constructive side of this orientation through rules, agreements, policies, contracts, fairness, consistency and transparency. These are valuable characteristics of an executive decision environment. But they become problematic when the ability to justify a decision becomes more important than exercising judgement about what the situation actually requires.

Maya had begun to ask, "Can I prove this is right?" instead of, "What is right here, given what we know?"

That distinction mattered. The strategy was transformational and involved considerable uncertainty. Not everything could be specified in advance. Yet the organisation was increasingly behaving as though uncertainty itself were a governance failure.

The source material describes how disabling guilt can shift attention toward finding fault rather than learning from mistakes, with consequences for collaboration, creativity and willingness to speak openly. For a transformation programme, this can be particularly damaging because strategic implementation inevitably involves experimentation, adaptation and ambiguity.

Maya recognised the pattern when a talented young manager told her:

"People don't want to make a mistake anymore."

That was not what the strategy required.

Maya had allowed Legitimacy to become the dominant bearing. She needed to recover the question: "Who is affected by this decision, and what do I owe them?" That brought Relational Obligation back into the conversation. But she also needed Agency, because knowing what is right does not, by itself, make something happen.

When Agency Takes Command

Nine months into the strategy, the board became impatient. The financial benefits were not appearing quickly enough, and the CEO told Maya that the programme needed to accelerate.

Maya responded decisively. She centralised key decisions, replaced two programme leaders, imposed new deadlines and told regional executives exactly what they were expected to deliver.

The programme moved.

For the first time in months, everyone knew Maya was in charge.

And that was precisely the problem.

Agency is essential to executive leadership. The Power/Fear material recognises the importance of hierarchy, influence, decision-making authority and empowerment. Used constructively, power can create clarity, accelerate decisions and enable people to act.

Maya was experiencing the attractive side of Agency. Decisions were being made. People were acting. The strategy was moving. But then dissent became increasingly difficult. Executives who questioned decisions were labelled resistant. Managers who asked for more time were seen as lacking commitment.

Maya began to believe that if she had the authority to make a decision, she also had the justification to impose it.

Agency had become control.

Her question had shifted from *"What can I do?"* to *"How do I make this happen?"*

The distinction is subtle but fundamental. The original Power/Fear material makes an important distinction between power and its misuse: power is understood as the capacity to cause reality to match one's will, while its misuse occurs when an individual causes someone else's reality to match their will instead of theirs.

Maya was beginning to cross that boundary. She was no longer simply exercising Agency; she was diminishing the Agency of others.

Her corrective question became: "What does my intervention enable—and what does it make impossible?"

That question brought Relational Obligation back into the room. And it brought Legitimacy with it, because the fact that Maya *could* act did not necessarily mean that she *should*

The Decision That Finally Changed Her

The defining moment came almost a year into the transformation.

The board asked Maya to close a regional business. The business was strategically misaligned and underperforming. The numbers were clear. But the regional CEO had served the organisation for twenty-five years. He was respected by his people and had built the business from scratch.

Maya sat alone with the decision. For the first time, she consciously recognised the three bearings.

Her Relational Obligation told her: *"This person has given twenty-five years of his life to this organisation. I owe him a fair hearing."*

Her Legitimacy told her: *"The business no longer fits the strategy, and continuing to fund it cannot be justified."*

Her Agency told her: *"I have the authority to close it."*

None of the three was wrong.

That was the point.

The problem was not finding the correct bearing. It was holding the bearings together long enough to exercise judgement.

Maya eventually decided to close the business. But she did so differently from how she might have done twelve months earlier. She met the regional CEO personally, explained the reasoning, acknowledged what he had built and did not hide behind policy. She did not pretend the decision was painless, and she did not avoid making it simply because the relationship mattered.

She exercised Agency. She grounded it in Legitimacy. And she carried the decision as an expression of Relational Obligation rather than as an escape from it.

That was a very different kind of executive judgement.

When One Bearing Becomes Sovereign

This is where the idea of executive judgement running riot becomes important.

The problem is not that Maya had strong relational instincts. The problem was that Relational Obligation became sovereign. The problem was not that she valued rules and defensibility. The problem was that Legitimacy became sovereign. The problem was not that she could act decisively. The problem was that Agency became sovereign.

Each strength had become a liability through overuse.

The source material makes precisely this distinction: the positive expressions of Honor, Innocence and Power can themselves become problematic when overused.

We can therefore describe three characteristic forms of executive judgement failure.

When Relational Obligation runs riot, *"I owe them"* overwhelms *"Is this right?"* and *"What should I do?"*

When Legitimacy runs riot, *"I need to be right"* overwhelms *"Who am I responsible to?"* and *"What must I do?"*

When Agency runs riot, *"I can do it"* overwhelms *"Should I?"* and *"Who bears the consequences?"*

The executive may remain intelligent, rational and highly experienced. But their judgement has become captured by their dominant bearing.

Learning To Correct the Bearing

Maya did not need to become less relational. She did not need to abandon governance. She did not need to become less decisive. She needed to become more conscious of when another bearing needed to correct her dominant one.

That is the developmental proposition at the heart of the Executive Sextant.

A sextant does not steer the ship. It helps the navigator establish position. The Executive Sextant serves a similar purpose. It does not tell an executive which decision to make; it helps reveal the worldview conditions through which the executive is making the decision.

The objective is therefore not perfect balance. It is adaptive judgement.

An executive with a strong Relational Obligation orientation may need to deliberately activate Legitimacy and Agency. An executive with a strong Legitimacy orientation may need to deliberately activate Relational Obligation and Agency. An executive with strong Agency may need to deliberately activate Relational Obligation and Legitimacy.

The question becomes:

Which bearing do I naturally trust—and which bearing do I need to deliberately bring into the decision?

The Executive Judgement Check

Maya eventually developed a simple discipline before making consequential decisions.

First, she considered Relational Obligation: *Who am I responsible to—and what do my relationships require of me?* This was not simply about who would be happy with her. It was about understanding the responsibilities and commitments she genuinely carried.

Second, she considered Legitimacy: *What is right, appropriate and defensible here?* This went beyond asking what the policy permitted. It required her to consider what she could genuinely stand behind.

Third, she considered Agency: *What can I do—and what will my action enable or constrain?* This moved beyond the question of what authority she possessed to consider the consequences created by exercising that authority.

Then came the question she found hardest:

Where are these three bearings aligned—and where are they in tension?

That was usually where the real judgement began.

Because executive judgement is rarely tested when everything points in the same direction. It is tested when what you owe, what is right and what you can do are not the same thing.

The Executive Who Learned to Navigate Differently

A year later, the strategy was succeeding.

Not perfectly. There had been departures, mistakes and compromises. Some decisions had taken longer than Maya would have liked, while others had been more painful than she expected. But the organisation was changing.

And Maya had changed with it.

She had learned that relational sensitivity did not mean avoiding difficult decisions. She had learned that legitimacy did not mean waiting for certainty. She had learned that agency did not mean imposing her will.

Most importantly, she had learned that her strongest way of seeing the organisation was not necessarily the only way the organisation needed to be seen.

That became her new discipline. Before difficult decisions, she would ask herself what she was seeing through her preferred bearing, what she might be missing, and which of the other bearings needed to correct her judgement.

She had not become a different leader.

She had become a more reflexive one.

When Executive Judgement Runs Riot

Every executive has a way of seeing. Some instinctively see relationships, commitments and obligations. Others see principles, standards and what is right. Others see possibilities, influence and what can be done.

All three are necessary.

The danger begins when one becomes the whole horizon.

When Relational Obligation runs riot, loyalty can become a substitute for judgement.

When Legitimacy runs riot, compliance can become a substitute for judgement.

When Agency runs riot, power can become a substitute for judgement.

Mature executive judgement requires something harder than choosing between them. It requires the executive to hold them in tension:

- Who am I responsible to—and what do my relationships require of me?
- What is right?
- What can I do—and what will my action enable or constrain?

The quality of executive judgement may therefore depend less on having the "right" worldview than on recognising when one's own worldview has become too powerful.

Because executives rarely lose their way because they have no bearing.

They lose their way because they mistake their bearing for the horizon.

And perhaps that is the central insight of the Executive Sextant:

Executive judgement is not about finding the perfect course. It is about knowing when your bearing needs to be corrected.